a deal with a ₹65,000 fee. We were ecstatic." This humble residential root paved the way for milestones scaled organically: from single plots to row houses, from high-rises to local shopping centres and then, a direct, explosive leap into the crown jewel of Delhi retail, Select CITYWALK.

FOXING THE EYE

When tasked with landmark national monuments like Vanijya Bhawan (the first post-Independence building constructed on the historic India Gate Hexagon) and Kaushal Bhawan, the ultimate test was preserving design integrity against an evolving rotating door of clients. "The formula is simple to state but brutal to execute," explains Chauhan. "You must enunciate the vision and the purpose so that while decision-makers on the government side change during the course of the project, the design premise does not change." In fact, the Vanijya Bhawan required what Chauhan calls foxing the eye. Standing adjacent to Lutyens' historic Hyderabad House, DFI chose to leave structural greed on the table. They voluntarily refused to consume the full Floor Area Ratio (FAR), keeping the building strictly under the 20-to-26-metre tree line. By terracing the six-storey structure backwards and pushing the building four metres behind massive, four-foot-diameter columns, they visually tricked the brain. "When you stand there, it looks like a three-storey building. We foxed the eye," adds a very proud Chauhan.

If Vanijya Bhawan was about optical illusions, Kaushal Bhawan was a battleground for environmental preservation. The plot, used for decades to store Republic Day parade stands, had grown into a dense, untouched forest of ancient peepal trees. Rather than bulldozing the green canopy, Chauhan engineered a structure that floated above the trees, lifting the main building from the fifth floor upward while letting only the structural lift cores pierce the ground. The vision outlasted five shifting government secretaries, some of whom were furious that this ecological experiment had wasted a year of the timeline on an architect's whim. To protect the trees from nocturnal contractor sabotage, Chauhan deployed a distinctly Indian strategy. "We put sacred red *mouli* threads around all the trees and told the labourers to pray here. No one dared touch them after that." When the project concluded, the natural Venturi effect created a micro-climate so breezy that the opening ceremony was conducted comfortably without fans or AC. The ultimate vindication came when the President of India overstayed her strict inauguration protocol, as she was utterly fascinated by the floating canopy.





SHAPING SKYLINES
(clockwise from top left) Delhi High Court, WoCO One; One by MSN; Eldeco Centre